

Down The Stretch — Website Partner Onboarding

A briefing for the person taking on the website's structure, look, and feel. Read this top to bottom once; it's everything you need to get oriented. If you're using an AI assistant (like Claude / Cowork) to help with the work, you can paste this whole document in at the start of a fresh chat so it understands the project.

1. What Down The Stretch is

Down The Stretch AI (downthestretch.ai) is a thoroughbred horse-racing handicapping service. It's a modern rebrand of an earlier brand, *BeTheSmartMoney*.

The product is simple to describe: every race day, the system publishes **PDF "sheets"** — one per racetrack — that contain model-driven, AI-assisted picks and analysis for each race. A subscriber logs in, sees the day's available tracks, and opens the sheet for the track they're playing.

There are two versions of each sheet:

- **PREVIEW** — published the night before, based on the morning-line entries.
- **FINAL** — published on race day, reflecting scratches and jockey changes.

The picks come from a proprietary scoring model (years of racing data + machine learning). That's the "product," and it's a **separate workstream** from the website — it's generated by a Python pipeline the owner maintains. You don't need to touch or understand it. Your world is the website that wraps around it.

2. Who it's for

Four audiences, in the brand's own words: **owners, trainers/agents, bettors, and fans**. The positioning is deliberately **premium** — "the premier name in handicapping," not "just another picker." The tone blends *racing heritage and tradition* with *modern machine intelligence*. Think trustworthy, refined, a little prestigious — not loud or gimmicky.

3. How it makes money (the funnel)

Understanding the funnel matters for design, because the marketing site's #1 job is to move a visitor toward a purchase. The plans:

Plan	Price	Notes
Day Pass	\$9	One track, one date — sold contextually when someone hits a locked sheet

7-Day Pass	\$39	One-time, all tracks for a week
Monthly	\$59 / month	Subscription, all access
Annual	\$590 / year	Subscription, best value
Saratoga Meet Pass	\$99	One-time, full meet (more meet passes will be added)

New visitors get a **1-day free trial** that requires only an email — **no credit card**. (This is intentional; the owner dislikes "free trials" that demand a card up front. The point is to capture an email and let people taste the product.)

The signup/login is **passwordless** — you enter your email and get a magic sign-in link. There's no password to remember.

4. Brand identity

The visual language already exists. Please build on it rather than reinventing it. There are brand reference files in the project folder you should look at first:

- *Down The Stretch AI — Brand Guidelines 2026.pdf*
- *Down The Stretch AI — Brand Identity_v2.pdf*
- *Down The Stretch AI — Partner & Investor Pitch.pdf* (great for voice + positioning)
- Logo/banner assets: `DTS_banner .png`, `DTS .png`, and related PNGs

Color palette (already coded into the site):

Name	Hex	Use
Deep Forest	<code>#0D2B1E</code>	Primary dark green background
Racing Gold	<code>#C9A84C</code>	Accent — headlines, buttons, highlights
Warm Ivory	<code>#F5F0E8</code>	Primary text on dark
Sage Mist	<code>#8BAF8E</code>	Muted green-gray — secondary text, borders
Track Earth	<code>#3D2B1E</code>	Warm brown — panels, depth

Typography: Display/headlines use a serif (**Constantia**, falling back to Georgia); body copy uses **Calibri**. The overall feel is a dark, forest-green canvas with gold accents — sophisticated and turf-club, not neon-sportsbook.

Voice, from the current homepage: - Eyebrow: *"Racing Intelligence, Refined"* - Headline: *"Intelligence at Full Stride for the modern racing world."* - Subhead: *"Down The Stretch AI combines deep industry experience, proprietary data, and machine learning to turn racing uncertainty into actionable advantage."* - Tagline used in the nav: *"AI for Racing."*

5. What the website looks like today

It's a real, working site (built and deployed), with two kinds of pages:

Marketing pages — this is your playground. - The **home/landing page**, made of sections: a top nav, a hero, "pillars," an audience section, a heritage section, a call-to-action, and a footer. - `/platform` and `/waitlist` links exist in the design but are thin/placeholder — good candidates for you to build out.

App pages — these work and are styled functionally, but the look is plain and could use your eye. - `/login` (magic-link sign-in), `/sheets` (the list of available sheets), `/buy` (the pricing page), `/account` (member dashboard), and the checkout/success flow.

Heads-up: right now the marketing pages and the app pages use **two slightly different styling systems**, so they don't feel perfectly unified yet. The owner is having that cleaned up (a shared "design system") so your styling choices can flow across the whole site consistently. You'll be told when that's ready.

6. Your role — and the one hard rule

You own: the structure, layout, look, feel, copy, imagery, and overall design of the site — both the marketing pages and (once the cleanup above is done) the appearance of the app pages.

You must not change: the **purchasing and login machinery**. This is the part that takes payments, grants access, and protects the paid PDFs — it took serious effort to build and verify, and a small accidental change can break real payments. Concretely, the "do not touch" zone is the code that handles checkout, the Stripe payment webhook, subscriptions, login/sessions, the access checks that gate the PDFs, and the database. You can change how the buy page and account page *look*; you should not change how they *work*.

In practice the project is set up so this is enforced for you — the sensitive files require the owner's review before any change to them can go live, so you can work freely without worrying about wandering into the wrong place. If something you want to restyle seems to be tangled up with that machinery, just flag it and the owner will separate the visual part out for you.

7. How the site is built (light version)

You do **not** need to be a developer to contribute, but here's the lay of the land so nothing is mysterious:

- It's a **Next.js / React** website (the standard modern web framework) styled with **Tailwind CSS**.
- It's hosted on **Vercel** and lives at **downthestretch.ai**.
- The code lives in a **GitHub** repository (the owner will give you access).
- Every change you make on your own working "branch" automatically gets its own **live preview link** on Vercel, so you can see your work on the real site before anything goes public. Nothing you do on a branch affects the live site until it's reviewed and merged.

You will **never need** any passwords, payment keys, or database access to do design work — and you shouldn't be given them. Design lives entirely in the visual layer.

8. Getting started

1. **Look at the brand files** listed in section 4 so you absorb the intended voice and visuals.
2. **Visit the live site** (downthestretch.ai) and click through every page, including signing up with the free trial, so you feel the current experience end to end.
3. **Get repo access** from the owner (GitHub), plus the preview link for the current build.
4. **Start with the marketing pages** — the homepage and the thin `/platform` and `/waitlist` pages are the highest-impact, lowest-risk place to begin. The app-page restyling comes after the design-system cleanup.
5. If you use an AI assistant to help write/adjust code, **paste this document in first** and tell it you're working only on marketing/design, not the payment or login code.

9. Good first opportunities

- Flesh out `/platform` (what the product is, how it works) and `/waitlist` (or convert it toward "Start your free day").
- Tighten the homepage story for each of the four audiences (owners, trainers, bettors, fans).
- Strengthen the path from "curious visitor" → "free trial" → "paid plan."
- Once the design-system cleanup lands: give the `/sheets`, `/buy`, and `/account` pages the same premium polish as the marketing pages (today they're a bit utilitarian, and one of them is even slightly misaligned — easy wins).

Questions about scope, access, or what's safe to change → ask the owner. When in doubt about whether something is "design" or "machinery," ask before changing it. Welcome aboard.